Volunteer Newsletter

October 2026

Hello Birmingham River Champions! Welcome to the Octobert edition of the Birmingham River Champions Volunteer Newsletter. Read on to learn a little bit about what your autumn Riverfly samples might look like, as well as some updates from the project team! To make up for us missing the September newsletter, attached to this email is also an update on the outfall pollution monitoring project.

Urban Riverfly In Autumn



Now that autumn we are well into autumn, and the days are getting shorter, you may be wondering “what will I see in my kick sample?” There are some species you can expect to see all year round, including aquatic hoglouse, Gammarus, and worms (or Oligochaeta), as they spend their whole life in the water.
For other species that emerge out of the water, their presence in your kick sample will depend on where in their lifecycle they are, which varies from species to species.

Many things that we look for in a kick sample will emerge from the water in late spring (hence “may”flies) or summer, so their abundances in your kick samples can be depressed in summer. Their abundance may then bounce back during autumn when the eggs have hatched and larvae start to develop. The Environment Agency typically sample during spring and autumn to best capture this biodiversity!

Of course, this effect can vary between sites and is dependent on the species (e.g., ‘cased caddisflies’ have 100s of different species), their genetics, their adaptability to environmental conditions etc.

One species with a notably different life cycle in the blue-winged, which often emerge during summer and then they lay eggs in the water. These eggs enter a state of dormancy (or diapause) over winter, which means that you won’t see these larvae until later next spring / summer.

All in all, expect to see more expect to see more species like mayflies and caddisflies that may have been less abundant over summer!



Picnic at the Park with Friends of Bournville Park

Caroline, Safina and Lily were out at Friends of Bournville Park's Picnic at the Park at the end of August!

The three of them had a great time showing off Urban Riverfly monitoring (and had lots of help seperating species).

If your group are hosting an event and would like the BRC team to host a stall, email us at BirminghamRiverChampions@gmail.com.



The Volunteer Feedback Survey is still live!

We want to hear from you!

Every now and then, we like to check in on how river monitoring is going for you.

Which parts of BRC do you like? Which parts can the BRC team improve? And what other events would you like to see this winter?

The survey should take no more than 5 minutes.

Complete the survey by clicking HERE.

An Update From Safina



I have been out sampling with groups like Friends of Senneleys Park and Kings Norton Nature Reserve, making notable finds like a predaceous diving beetle, horsehair parasitic worms, and great water boatmen!

Our student sampling sessions have also been ongoing, with us and presenting Bronze Awards to two dedicated volunteers who reached the five-session milestone!

I've also been working with the Blossom and Smartwater projects, collecting samples from outfalls and analysing their ‘spectral’ properties in the lab.

By combining physical stream observations with accurate laboratory testing, we are aiming to pinpoint notable outfalls, trace pollution sources, and potentially even help drive essential repairs across the catchment! You can read more about this project in the last community update here!



Rugby River Champions in action!

Caroline has been working hard behind the scenes to set up this project's sister project, Rugby River Champions!

The first Rugby River Champions training session took place on September 21st, with 13 people attending in total, a brilliant start for the brand new project!



Dissertation: Volunteer Thoughts on the Riverfly Project

Joe, a Geography student from Coventry University, is asking for volunteers to complete a questionnaire about their experiences carrying out Riverfly sampling as a part of his dissertation.

If you would like to take part, you can view the questionnaire here.
Good luck with your dissertation Joe!

ARMI Trigger Levels

James has been working on a larger report on ARMI scores for sites monitored by you. The full report will hit your inbox soon, but the key takeaways are:

- The Urban Riverfly citizen science data collected has afforded invaluable insights into how the ecological health of Birmingham's rivers can vary in space and time;
- Sutton Park evidently supports the most biodiverse rivers regionally (of those sampled);
- But, some pollution sensitive species have been observed in areas of the upper Cole and Bartley Brook at Senneleys Park;
- Critically, the longer-term datasets haven't shown any strong evidence of consistent declines in ARMI scores, with most sites tending to show no obvious trend over time (but there is strong variability within this);
- Of those sites that have had trigger levels set by the Environment Agency, none have breached this twice consecutively.

We will continue trying to interrogate this data to see what this can tell us about the health of Birmingham's rivers and how this can be improved. This includes looking into the calculation of the ARMI metric and if this can be improved; more closely examining how specific species are responding to add a bit more meaning to the ARMI changes.

Birmingham River Champions

Monitor your river
Protect your river
Love your river

If you wish to no longer recieve these emails, please contact the project team via the email below.

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